

The 6:15

FRIDAY · AUGUST 14, 2026

NO. 4

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Fri 8/14	July retail sales (Census, 8:30a ET), cons. +0.3% MoM ex-auto (Dow Jones); prelim UMich sentiment (10a) — both not yet released as of press time
Mon 8/17	13-wk/26-wk T-bill auctions; 30-yr Treasury bond auction (carried from last issue, not reconfirmed this run)
Tue 8/18	FL, AK, WY state primaries; Home Depot (HD) earnings, BMO
Wed 8/20	Walmart (WMT) earnings, BMO
Tue 9/16	Next FOMC decision
AI models	[NEW] xAI's Grok 4.6 (8/12) and DeepSeek's V4-Pro-0813 (8/13) both shipped this week

OPEC+: no ministerial confirmed in this window; 68th JMMC not until 10/4. No verified rocket-launch or major VC-round item cleared the bar this run — omitted rather than padded. Jackson Hole (8/27-29, Warsh's first keynote as Fed chair, Fri 8/28) falls just outside the 10-day window; flagged here for continuity, not carried as a full line.

METRICS · ~5:10A ET FRI 8/14 UNLESS NOTED

Brent (ICE front)	\$87.23, +0.18% (oilprice.com quote, 5:08a) — Thu settle not independently confirmed this run
WTI (NYMEX front)	\$81.78, +0.65% (oilprice.com quote, 5:08a); Thu settled down >2% near \$81, first drop after 5 straight up sessions (CNBC)
Brent-WTI spread	\$5.45
UST 10Y	4.645% (Thu 8/13 close, CNBC)
UST 2Y / 30Y	4.20% / 5.24% (Wed 8/12 close, Fed H.15 — Thu close not independently confirmed)
DXY	99.87, -0.14% (Thu 8/13 close)
S&P 500 / Nasdaq Comp.	7,798.99 +0.7% (record close) / 26,803.03 +0.81% (Thu 8/13 close)

S&P / Nasdaq-100 futures	+0.01% / -0.15% (Fri premarket, single-source quote)
VIX	14.45 (Thu 8/13 close — lowest since January)
Gold (spot)	\$4,354.22, -1.23% (Thu 8/13 close, off a 10-week intraday high)
Nikkei / Hang Seng	68,308.59 +1.16% / 25,396.51 -0.17% (Thu 8/13 close)
Europe (Thu close)	FTSE 10,833.15 -0.10%; DAX 26,299.74 -0.12%; CAC 8,674.94 -0.46%
Retail gas, natl. avg.	\$4.0715/gal (AAA, as of 8/13)

Equities/rates from exchange and CNBC quote pages; crude per source-of-record rules below.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure	Day 166 (straits.live, as of 10:23 UTC 8/14)
Transits vs. baseline	1 vessel on 8/9 vs. ~73/day pre-crisis (IMF/PortWatch AIS, multi-day lag); straits.live: ~1% of normal throughput, last 24h
Weekly transits	78 total, wk of 8/3-8/9 (vs. a revised 95 the prior week) ; non-Iranian-linked westbound: 23 in the wk to ~8/12, down from 28 (Lloyd's List, preliminary)
Strikes, 24-48h	≥2 new incidents: drone strike on an outbound tanker (UKMTO-confirmed, minor damage, no injuries, night of 8/13-14) and a second, separate attack on 2 ADNOC vessels (UAE-confirmed, no injuries, evening 8/13)
Dark tankers	58 AIS-dark, last 24h, vs. a 40.4 7-day average (straits.live)
War-risk premium	30.0x pre-crisis; ~\$10.0M per VLCC passage, unchanged vs. last issue (straits.live)

PortWatch/AIS counts individual vessel movements with a multi-day lag; Lloyd's List aggregates weekly commercial transits >10,000 dwt with Iran-link attribution and revises preliminary weekly counts upward later; straits.live blends broker war-risk quotes with dark-ship detection in near-real time. Separately, marine-insurance broker reporting has also quoted Hormuz premiums as 3-10% of hull value (vs. a 0.25% pre-crisis baseline) — a different unit than straits.live's multiple, and not convertible without each policy's hull-value basis. Three-plus universes on different clocks; don't average or net them against each other.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees / Knicks / Northwestern	No reported roster moves in the last 24 hours
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Basij commander claims Hormuz is "under Iran's control" as attacks intensify — and oil fell anyway

Iran escalated its pushback against Trump's "total control" claim on Thursday, and for the first time did so through the newly reshuffled chain of command rather than only the foreign ministry. Hossein Taeb — the Khamenei loyalist installed atop the Basij paramilitary in Sunday's reshuffle — said the strait is "under Iran's control and management," while Iran's joint military command separately declared that no vessel can transit without Tehran's permission, calling U.S. claims of normal passage "lies and falsehoods." [fact: statements confirmed Thursday] Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi went further, saying Washington has "long miscalculated due to intelligence failures" and calling the war itself "an even bigger miscalculation." [fact] This is the first time the command structure installed after February's succession has been invoked in an actual public dispute rather than described in the abstract — read as evidence that stacking loyalists atop the Basij and IRGC was about building a coherent line of authority for exactly this kind of confrontation, not just internal security. [read]

The rhetoric coincided with the worst 24-48 hours for vessel safety in weeks. A commercial tanker was struck by a drone on an outbound transit overnight (UKMTO-confirmed, minor damage, no injuries), and separately ADNOC said two of its vessels were attacked Thursday evening — the UAE's second such incident in under a week, prompting Abu Dhabi to formally invoke UN Security Council Resolution 2817 on freedom of navigation. [fact] Two

attacks in roughly a day, layered onto Trump's Wednesday claim that the U.S. "own[s]" the strait and "might keep it," is a sharper contradiction than the general disagreement carried in prior issues — a live claim of control is now being answered with live attacks on shipping. [read]

Shipping data is unusually unanimous on direction even as vendors disagree on magnitude and timing. IMF PortWatch's lagged AIS count showed just 1 vessel transiting Aug. 9 against a ~73/day pre-crisis baseline; straits.live puts last-24h throughput at roughly 1% of normal; and Lloyd's List's slower weekly aggregate shows both total transits (78, week of 8/3-8/9, down from a revised 95) and the non-Iranian-linked westbound subset (23 in the week to ~8/12, down from 28) falling for a second straight week. [fact, three sources, one direction]

Yet Brent and WTI both fell Thursday — WTI settled down more than 2% near \$81, its first drop after five straight sessions of gains — and are only fractionally higher (Brent +0.18%, WTI +0.65%) in early Friday trade. [fact] That divergence is worth flagging rather than smoothing over: crude is trading on the macro backdrop — soft PPI, falling rate-hike odds, demand-side caution explicitly cited in Thursday's oil commentary — even as the physical security picture in the strait deteriorated further. [read] Either the market is treating further escalation as already priced into a persistent high-\$80s Brent handle, or it's under-pricing the risk that a second consecutive ADNOC attack is an emerging pattern rather than a one-off. The data available this run can't distinguish between those two reads, and that ambiguity is itself the tradeable fact for the desk this morning. [read]

The Fed angle from Wednesday's CPI carries through. Soft CPI (+0.1% headline MoM, +3.4% YoY) and Thursday's even softer PPI (flat MoM vs. +0.2% consensus, annual rate down to 4.7% from 5.5%) have pulled September hike odds down from the roughly 60% flagged in the last issue — CME FedWatch and Kalshi disagree on the exact level (readings this run ranged roughly 30-40% on CME, 30% on Kalshi) but both now put a hold as the base case. [fact, hedge on precision] A market pricing disinflation and de-risking Hormuz at the same time is either coherent — both signal a Fed that doesn't need to lean harder into what looks like a contained supply shock — or contradictory, since oil's stickiness is exactly the risk that could reverse the disinflation trade. Friday's retail sales, still unreleased as of this writing, is the next data point that tests which read holds. [DEVELOPING] For a desk positioned around energy and rates simultaneously, the trade this morning isn't "pick a side" — it's recognizing that both markets are pricing genuinely different information sets (crude on macro-and-inflation data, the strait's physical risk on incident-by-incident escalation) that happen to be moving in opposite directions this week, and that the two will only reconverge once one set of data stops updating faster than the other. [read]

POLITICS

The House-Senate funding standoff sharpened this week rather than resolving. [NEW] The Senate passed its own continuing resolution 90-6 before recessing, funding the government through Dec. 11 and including negotiated riders — blocking a proposed rule expanding political appointees' role in federal grant review, and barring fund transfers to Border Patrol. But the House, before its own recess, had already passed a narrower version funding only through Dec. 4 with

none of the Senate's carve-outs, opposed by most House Democrats. The chambers now hold two incompatible bills with both out of session into September, leaving reconciliation undone heading toward the Sept. 30 fiscal year-end — a wider gap than the "House still has to act" framing carried last issue suggested. The practical read for the desk: neither chamber can amend or conference the other's bill until members are back in Washington, which pushes any resolution mechanism into a compressed post-Labor-Day window rather than the calmer run-up investors had been pricing, and raises (without yet confirming) the odds of a stopgap-on-a-stopgap rather than a clean reconciliation. [read] Tuesday's Florida, Alaska and Wyoming primaries are the next election-calendar item inside the 10-day window, unrelated to the funding fight.

ECONOMICS

July's CPI (BLS, Wed 8:30a ET) rose 0.1% MoM, 3.4% YoY headline; core rose 0.2% MoM, 2.5% YoY — a second straight month of cooling, with shelter (+0.1%, roughly two-thirds of the monthly gain) still the primary driver and energy down 1.5% MoM despite being up 14.7% YoY on the year's earlier gasoline spike. [fact] Thursday's PPI came in even softer: final demand flat MoM against a 0.2% consensus, with the annual rate falling to 4.7% from 5.5% in June as energy costs eased. [fact] Jobless claims ticked up to 209,000 for the week of 8/8 (vs. 202,000 consensus), but continuing claims fell to 1.777 million and the four-week moving average has held below 200,000 for a second straight week — a historically tight labor market cooling at the margin, not deteriorating. [fact] Together, the two soft inflation prints are why September hike odds have fallen from the roughly 60% flagged last issue (see Lead); today's July retail sales and preliminary UMich sentiment — both unreleased as

of press time — are the next test of whether consumer spending is cracking under gas and grocery pass-through even as headline inflation cools. Consensus for retail sales ex-auto is +0.3% MoM (Dow Jones survey); a miss on the downside alongside soft CPI/PPI would strengthen the disinflation-plus-slowness-demand case, while a beat would reopen the "sticky services, resilient consumer" argument that's kept the Fed cautious about cutting further. [read] Both prints land two weeks ahead of Warsh's Aug. 28 Jackson Hole keynote — his first as chair — and will shape how much room he has to sound dovish without the bond market calling it premature, the same skepticism flagged after his hawkish-shock July meeting. [DEVELOPING]

BUSINESS

CoreWeave's Q2 (Tue AMC) beat on both lines — revenue \$2.6B (+112% YoY) against a \$2.56B consensus, adjusted loss of \$1.14/share versus \$1.41 expected — with backlog above \$104B and shares jumping as much as 13% after hours. [fact, resolves last issue's DEVELOPING tag] Net losses still widened to \$626M from \$290M a year ago on higher interest costs — the debt-load-versus-backlog tension flagged last issue hasn't gone away, it's just being outrun by growth for now. [read] Cisco's Q4 FY26 (Wed AMC) beat and raised: revenue \$17.3B (+18% YoY), non-GAAP EPS \$1.22 (+23%), next-quarter guidance of \$18-18.2B ahead of consensus, on \$9.3B in full-year AI-infrastructure orders. Shares fell anyway — a beat-and-sell reaction without a clearly agreed driver in the coverage reviewed this run. [fact; cause unconfirmed, flagged] Applied Materials (Thu AMC) posted a record quarter — \$9.115B revenue (+25% YoY, +15% sequential), non-GAAP EPS \$3.50 versus \$3.45 consensus — narrowly missing on revenue against a \$9.176B

estimate, and guided Q4 to roughly $\$10.25\text{B} \pm \500M with non-GAAP EPS of about $\$4.02 \pm \0.20 . [fact] Read across the three prints together: CoreWeave and Applied Materials both cleared the bar comfortably (backlog growth, record equipment revenue), while Cisco's sell-the-beat reaction is the outlier — a reminder that "beat and raise" is being priced against increasingly demanding expectations rather than against the numbers in isolation, particularly for names already carrying AI-cycle premiums. [read] Nvidia's $\$500\text{B}$ financing-platform MOUs and TSMC's July revenue print are dropped this issue — neither has moved since last covered; no signed terms, no fresh stock reaction.

TECHNOLOGY

Frontier AI model releases kept churning this week: xAI shipped Grok 4.6 on Wednesday and DeepSeek followed with V4-Pro-0813 on Thursday, the latest entries in a cadence that's now essentially continuous across both U.S. and Chinese labs. [NEW, fact] Paired with Applied Materials' record equipment quarter and Cisco's $\$9.3\text{B}$ AI-order backlog (see Business), the read is that the hardware side of this cycle — chip-fab tooling and networking gear alike — is still tracking the pace of model releases rather than lagging behind it, the same demand-outrunning-supply pattern flagged in prior issues around Nvidia's financing push. [read] Notably, DeepSeek's release cadence (V4-Pro-0813, its naming convention now essentially date-stamped like a software build) underscores that open-weight Chinese labs are no longer trailing frontier U.S. labs by a model generation — the gap that mattered a year ago has compressed to weeks, which is the underlying reason equipment and networking demand hasn't slackened despite the capex-financing debate playing out in parallel (see Business). [read]

GEOPOLITICS

The UAE's response to Thursday's second ADNOC attack was more formal than after the first: Abu Dhabi's foreign ministry invoked UN Security Council Resolution 2817 by name, casting the strike as a violation of an international freedom-of-navigation guarantee rather than a bilateral shipping incident. [NEW] That's a shift in register from last issue's UAE response to the Kurdistan consular drone strike (material damage, no injuries, no resolution invoked) — Abu Dhabi appears to be building a documented, resolution-referenced case rather than reacting incident by incident, which will matter if the Saudi-Pakistan-Turkey defense pact signed last week is ever tested. No further movement this run on that pact, the Joint Chiefs off-ramp report, or the Houthi Jazan-refinery claim — all remain as previously reported and single-sourced where flagged. [continuity] The practical read for the region: a UAE that's now citing UN resolutions by number is laying groundwork for a multilateral response track distinct from whatever bilateral U.S.-Iran talks produce, which matters for how quickly (or slowly) Gulf shipping risk could normalize even if Washington and Tehran eventually strike a deal — insurers underwrite the physical risk, not the diplomacy, and a resolution-referenced dispute is a slower one to close than a bilateral spat. [read]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The insurance market's structural shift — six P&I clubs now refusing Hormuz war-risk cover outright, reported last issue — hasn't reversed; straits.live's 30.0x multiple and ~\$10.0M per-VLCC figure are unchanged since Tuesday despite zero new strikes being

logged between issues, consistent with the standing read that premiums fall only after sustained calm, not merely from an absence of new incidents. [read, continuity] Thursday's two attacks reset that clock rather than testing it — with a drone strike and a second ADNOC incident inside roughly 24 hours, the "sustained calm" window insurers would need to re-underwrite risk hasn't opened at all this week. [read] Dark-tanker activity ticked up to 58 vessels in the last 24 hours against a 40.4 seven-day average (straits.live) — one channel operators use to keep cargo moving without visible war-risk exposure, though by definition it isn't captured in any of the transit counts on the Board. [fact] The gap between that dark-fleet count and the single-digit visible-transit figures IMF PortWatch and straits.live both report is itself informative: more vessels appear willing to move cargo off-AIS than are willing to transit openly under the current risk pricing, which suggests the bottleneck is specifically insurable, visible passage rather than physical capacity or shipper demand. [read] None of this bears on the political dispute over who controls the strait (see Lead); it's a separate, slower-moving track that will likely lag any political resolution by weeks even if one arrives.

SPORTS

Yankees	Lost to Mariners 1-0 (Thu 8/13), after beating Seattle 10-5 (Wed 8/12). 66-52 (computed from last issue's 64-51 plus these two results; not independently reconfirmed this run), 3rd AL East. Next: continues vs. Seattle.
Knicks	Off-season, no game.
Northwestern	Off-season, no game. Opener 9/5 vs. South Dakota State.

Continuity. No issues published 8/12 or 8/13 — this issue covers the full three days since Tuesday's No. 3 and tags items accordingly. Dropped as unchanged/superseded: full Khamenei command-reshuffle roster (established; Basij commander's claim now covered as its first real-world

invocation); Nvidia's \$500B MOU and TSMC's July print (no movement since last issue); Warsh/Fed hawkish-shock backstory; Oman shipping-lane deal mechanics; war-powers vote details. For tomorrow: drop CoreWeave/Cisco/AMAT specifics once markets have digested them unless a fresh move; the funding-bill standoff should resolve or escalate once Congress returns in September; watch whether Thursday's two Hormuz attacks are a pattern before the next issue.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.